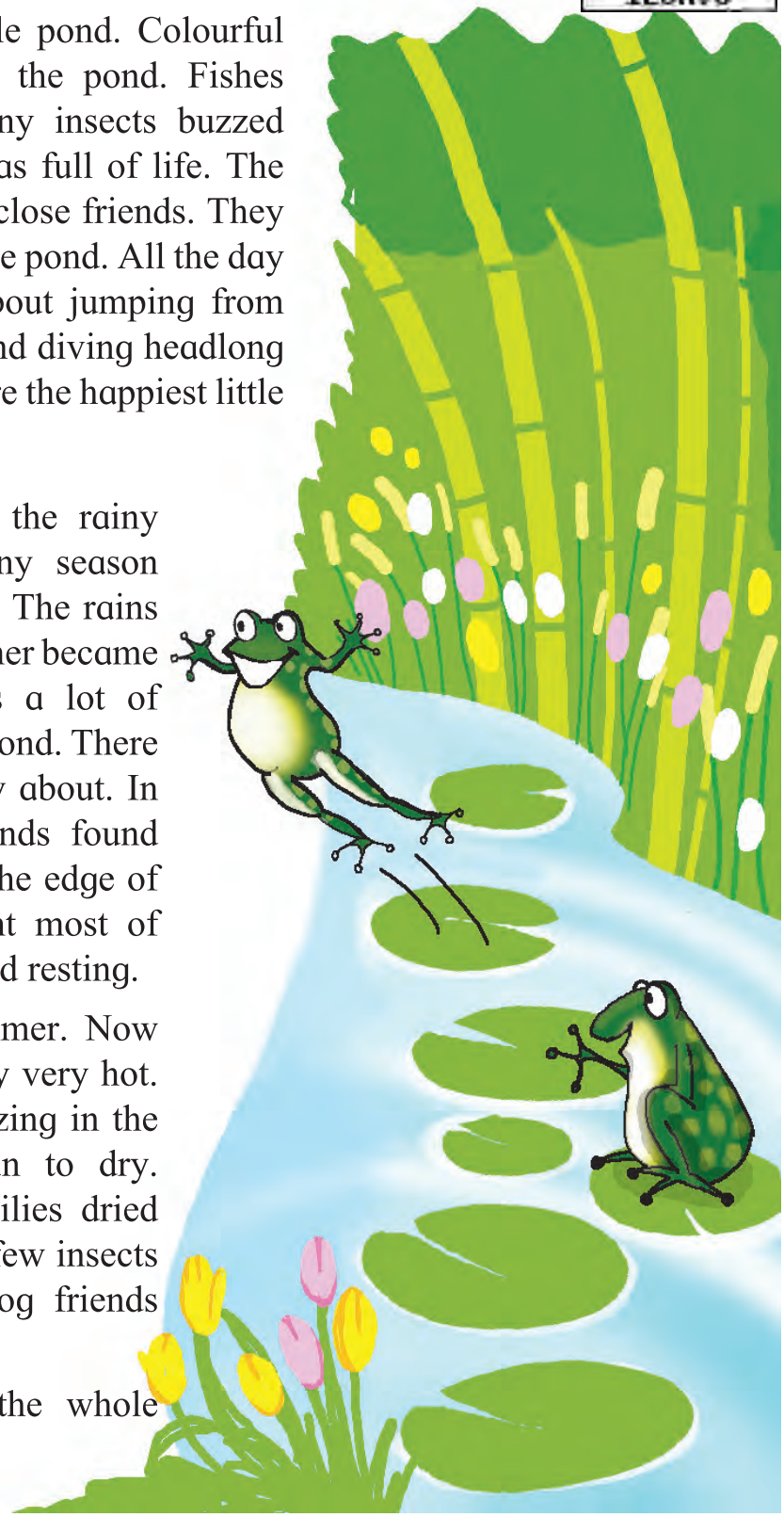
18. Look Before you Leap !

Long long ago, there lived two little frogs in a pretty little pond. Colourful water lilies grew in the pond. Fishes darted about and tiny insects buzzed around. The pond was full of life. The two frogs were very close friends. They had plenty to eat in the pond. All the day long, they played about jumping from lily pad to lily pad and diving headlong in the pond. They were the happiest little frogs in the world.



The frogs loved the rainy season. But the rainy season does not last forever. The rains stopped and the weather became hot. Still, there was a lot of water and life in the pond. There was nothing to worry about. In winter, the frog friends found cozy little places at the edge of the pond. They spent most of their time sleeping and resting.

Soon it was summer. Now the days became very very hot. With the hot sun blazing in the sky, the pond began to dry. Without water, the lilies dried up. There were very few insects to be found. The frog friends were worried.

"Do you think the whole pond will dry up ?"

"Looks like it," said the other.

"What shall we do then ? How shall we live ?"

"We must search a place where there is plenty of water and food for us."

"You are right. It is hard work, travelling in this hot sun. But there is no other way. Come, let us start. The sooner, the better."

"If we travel together, the search will be easier."

So the frogs left the drying pond and began to look for a watery place. They hopped and hopped and became very tired. Just then, one of them saw a well in the distance. They rushed to the well. The well was built in stone and had a high circular wall. The frogs hopped onto the wall and peeped inside. The well was quite deep, but there was a lot of water still left at the bottom of the well. The friends began to jump for joy.

"We are so fortunate ! Thank God that we found this well !"

"Our problem is solved ! Our search has ended ! We have found a new home ! Let's jump in together - one, two, ..."

"Wait ! Friend, this well is so deep. And there's water left only at the bottom."

"But we can surely dive in ! However deep the well may be, diving is our speciality ! Why do you hesitate ?"

"It has occurred to me that this well is also drying up. If it dries up completely, we will have to leave this well, too."

"I agree. But why do you hesitate now ?"

"It's because I see a problem. We can easily dive into the well. But what if the well dries up ? Can we jump so high that we reach the top of this wall ? Shall we be able to leave the well like we left the pond ?"

"You are right, friend !" said the other frog. "I had not thought of this. It's good that you could foresee this problem. Let's not leap inside. Let's continue with our search."

And so, the two little frogs hopped on to look for a safe shelter.

How well it is said, "Look before you leap !"

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• **darted :** moved quickly and suddenly. • **lily pad :** one of the floating leaves of a waterlily. • **headlong :** head first. 'Diving headlong' means diving into water with the head going into water first and then the rest of the body.

Things to do :

1. Answer the following questions :

   (a) What was the pond like in summer ?

   (b) Why were the frogs worried ?

   (c) Why did the frogs begin to jump for joy ?

   (d) What was the well like ? Describe it in two or three lines.

   (e) What problem did the frog see ?

2. Guess the meaning of the following phrases. Then use them in your own sentences –

   * long, long ago * all day long * last forever
   * jump for joy * The sooner, the better.

3. Describe the following in your own words, using your own ideas and experiences –

   (a) The rainy season (b) The cold season (c) The hot season.

4. What precautions will you take on the following occasions ?

   * Crossing the road
   * On a picnic in a new place
   * Boarding a bus or getting down from it
   * Going somewhere on your own
   * Jumping down
   * Climbing a tree

5. This is a story that explains the saying 'Look before you leap'.

   Can you think of stories that explain other proverbs ?

   Tell the story about any one of the following proverbs :

   * Self-help is the best help. * Slow but steady wins the race.
   * A friend in need is a friend indeed. * Union is strength.
   * Better late than never.

6. Make a collection of proverbs.